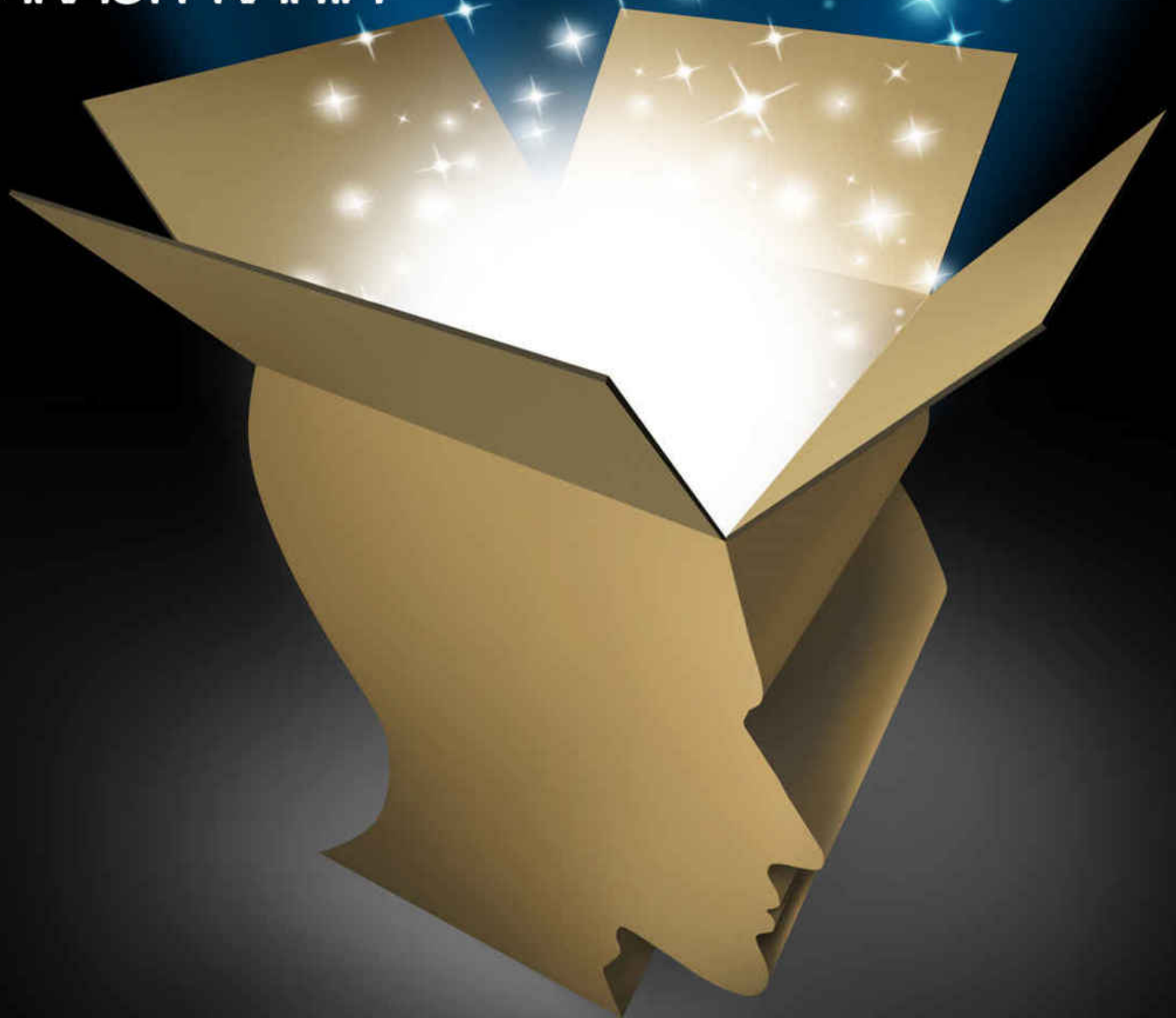


PERSUADE ANYONE

AKASH KARIA



**26 Powerful Techniques to
Persuade Anyone**

26 Ways to Persuade People to Do Stuff

The Psychology of Persuasion

AKASH KARIA

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“26 Ways to Persuade People to Do Stuff” is your secret to winning people over to your way of thinking

26 Ways to Persuade People to Do Stuff is a short, practical and step-by-step guide that will teach you how to win the game of persuasion. Based on scientifically proven principles, this book is a must-have for business owners, entrepreneurs, negotiators, salespeople and anyone else who could benefit from learning how to be more persuasive without being pushy.

Be Persuasive Without Being Pushy – Here’s How:

By the end of this guide, you will have picked up the tools and techniques to become twice as persuasive in half the time so that you can achieve your personal and business goals. Whether you’re an entrepreneur or a stay-at-home mom, *26 Ways to Persuade People to Do Stuff* will prove to be a valuable addition to any persuader’s library.

Not convinced yet? Here are just some of the cool persuasion techniques you learn inside the book:

- **Two Birds of a Feather:** Discover how to get your prospect to like you and buy from you.
- **The George Clooney/Halle Berry Effect:** Learn how research on the 1974 Canadian elections can help you become more persuasive.
- **Go the EDGE** – Use the four universal benefits to get people to say “Yes!”
- **The “Star Wars” Toothbrush Technique:** Find out how a Star Wars toothbrush can teach you about persuading people and gaining compliance.

- **The Expert Spillover Effect:** Discover how to taking advantage of the expert spillover effect can help you become more persuasive.
- **The “Yes Ladder”:** Learn one of the coolest persuasion techniques designed to help you build rapport with your prospects and lead them to a “Yes”.
- **The Fair Persuader:** Discover how being perceived as a fair persuader can actually make you *more* persuasive.
- **Inoculation:** Find out how to stop your prospects from changing their minds.
- **The Mint Sweet Gift:** Learn how waiters receive 20% more tips using this technique, and how you can use it too to increase your persuasion power.
- **The Petrified Forest Persuasion Failure:** Discover the (shocking) persuasion mistake most people make (and don’t even realize they’re making!)
- **The Rokia Technique:** Discover what a seven-year old girl in Mali named Rokia can teach you about unlocking your persuasion power.
- **The BYAF Technique:** Learn the scientifically proven BYAF technique that can *double* your chances of getting a “Yes!”

Why Not?

If you feel that learning any of these persuasion techniques could be useful in helping you achieve your personal and business goals, then what are you waiting for? Get the book! Why not? **Just one idea in the book might be what you need** to unlock your persuasion power. Your investment is cheaper than a cup of coffee, and there’s a seven-day money-back guarantee on all products purchased through Amazon.

Ready to get started? Then scroll up to buy the book...

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INTRODUCTION

WHEN THESE STRATEGIES WON'T WORK



In this book, you will learn the science behind how to persuade people to “do stuff” for you - without having to yell, threaten or be aggressive. You will learn proven persuasion principles to win people over to your way of thinking and get them to comply with your requests.

Think of the last time you had to persuade someone to do something for you. Was your persuasion attempt successful?

Why or why not?

What if you could learn persuasion strategies that would increase your chances of getting a “yes”?

How would that impact your personal life?

How would that impact your career?

When you think about it, a lot of life is about persuasion.

You go through life trying to persuade one person or another. During the job interview, you try to persuade the interviewer that you’re the right person for the job. You try to persuade your boyfriend/girlfriend to marry you (if you’re lucky, they try to persuade you!). You try to persuade your kids that they should work hard in school so that they can get a well-paying job later in life. You try to persuade your customers that they should buy your product instead of your competitor’s.

Almost every conversation - from where to go for dinner to what car to buy - contains some element of persuasion.

The aim of this short book is to equip you with **scientifically proven persuasion strategies** that will increase your odds of getting what you want - without yelling, threatening or being aggressive.

Will the persuasion strategies outlined in this book work 100% of the time?

Absolutely not.

I'll be the first to admit that the strategies in this book are not bulletproof. They're not going to work all the time and in every situation. But here's what they will do: They *will* increase your probability of hearing a "Yes!"

It may seem odd that even though I'm trying to persuade you to buy this book I'm telling you that the strategies covered in this book won't always work (***Persuasion alert: There's a scientifically proven reason as to why I'm doing this, which we'll cover in Chapter 4***). Like any technique, there are times when these persuasion techniques won't work.

These strategies won't work when:

- **The other person absolutely doesn't want to do what you're asking them do.** If someone is completely against doing what you're asking them to do (e.g. because it goes against their values and morals), it's going to be very difficult to persuade them.

You can't persuade someone who isn't even willing to hear you out. However, as long as you're talking to someone who is willing to hear your point of view, these strategies are designed to improve your odds of getting a "yes."

- **You're trying to manipulate the other person into doing something that's not good for them.** People aren't stupid. If you're trying to manipulate the other person into doing something that will be harmful to them (physically, emotionally, spiritually or financially), no technique will help you succeed. The techniques in this book will only work as long as both you and the other person genuinely benefit from the course of action you're recommending.

- **Your request is completely unreasonable.** Even with the use of these techniques, it's impossible to get someone to hand you a million dollars without any good reason. If your request is outrageous, people won't comply. However, as long as you're making a reasonable request, the techniques covered in this book will be useful in helping you increase your persuasive power.

WHAT YOU'LL LEARN IN THIS BOOK:

If you go to any bookstore, you'll find books on persuasion titled *101 Persuasion Strategies to Get Anything You Want*, *200 Ways to Persuade People* and *1001 Ways to Influence People*.

While there are thousands of ways to persuade people, in this book I cover only twenty-six of them.

Why only twenty-six?

I believe that these twenty-six strategies provide an outline that you can use in almost *any* situation. I may be biased, but they're among the most interesting techniques I've learned.

I hate reading books with "fluffy advice" such as "be nice," "make eye contact" and "be persistent." These pieces of advice don't help much and are not worth the price of the books.

Therefore, in this book, I've taken only the most interesting research on persuasion and packed it into a short, easy-to-read book. While this is a short book, the techniques and strategies you'll find inside are powerful, interesting and easy to apply to your everyday life.

Here are some of the interesting questions you will find the answers to in this book:

- "Be likeable" is a common advice in most books on persuasion, but **how exactly do you get people to like you?** What can you do to get other people to like you and hence be more easily persuaded by you? How do you get strangers to like you when you don't have much time together (e.g. during brief sales encounters)?

- Is it better to present a **one-sided argument** or a **balanced argument**? Which one is more persuasive and why?
- How do you get people to say “Yes!” even after they initially respond with a firm “No” to your request?

Here are some of the other things that you will learn in this book:

- An effective tool to **get people to change their own minds!**
- A simple technique that can **double your chances of getting a “Yes!”**

If that sounds like something that you’re interested in, then let’s get started.

CHAPTER ONE

HOW TO GET PEOPLE TO LIKE YOU (IN 90 SECONDS OR LESS)



It's no secret that people are more likely to do what you want when they like you (as compared with when people don't know you, or worse - don't like you!). Isn't it true that - no matter what the request - you're generally more likely to say "Yes" to someone you like than to someone you don't know?

From my extensive research, I have found that developing "likeability" is the first step in persuasion. If you can get the other person to like you, you're in a great position to get him/her to agree to your request. However, don't just take my word for it. This book is about the *science* of persuasion, so let's examine the science behind likeability.

In a study conducted by Frenzen and Davis (Jonathan K. Frenzen and Harry L. Davis, "Purchasing Behavior in Embedded Markets"), Frenzen and Davis examined the influence of liking on purchasing decisions at Tupperware parties.

Side note: In case you don't know what a Tupperware party is, it is a party where the Tupperware salesperson invites their friends and neighbors into their home to see (and hopefully buy) the product line.

In their study, Frenzen and Davis wanted to examine what was the more important factor in making a purchasing decision: the products themselves or the guests' liking for their host?

You would expect that since the guests would have to pay to purchase the Tupperware products, the most important factor in the purchasing decision would be

the guests' opinions of the products. After all, guests were there for the products, not for the host, right?

However, Frenzen and Davis's research found that that this wasn't true. It turns out the **guests' liking for their host was twice as important (as compared to their opinion of the products) in influencing purchasing decisions**. In other words, if you were hosting a Tupperware party, your likeability would be a better indicator of sales than your guests' opinion of the actual products themselves!

This isn't exactly breakthrough knowledge. It's common sense that it's easier to persuade people who like you than to persuade those who don't have positive feelings towards you. However, what's important to note from Frenzen and Davis's research is the fact that likeability is a lot more important in persuasion than we might have initially suspected (even more important than the products we are selling).

So, how do you develop likeability? How do get someone who you barely know to instantly like you so that they will buy your products and ideas?

#1 - "TWO BIRDS OF A FEATHER"

One of the easiest ways to become likeable is to demonstrate similarity with the target person. Demonstrating to the target person that you are in some way similar to them ("two birds of a feather") has been proven to cause the other person to like you more and be more willing to comply with your requests (as compared to if you didn't have anything in common).

Consider a study conducted by Aune and Basil (Aune & Basil, 1994). In the study, a fundraiser on a college campus managed to **more than double the contributions received simply by claiming a shared identity with the target person** (i.e. saying, "I'm a student too!").

Isn't that amazing? Contributions doubled simply because the fundraiser demonstrated that he was similar to the person he was seeking a contribution from.

What this study shows is that even superficial similarity between two people can create instant liking (which leads to greater compliance).

When trying to persuade people, first create liking by demonstrating that you are similar to the person you are trying to persuade.

Do you have a common hobby?

Or some kind of shared interest?

If so, start your conversation by talking about your common hobby. Only after you've created a bond by talking about a shared interest should you try to persuade the other person to do whatever it is that you want them to do.

Researchers have also found that apart from demonstrating similarity by talking about a shared identity, you can also create liking by dressing similarly to the person you are trying to persuade. Researchers have discovered that **people are more likely to help out a stranger when he is dressed similarly to them than when he isn't.**

Why is it that similarity leads to liking? Because it doesn't make sense to dislike someone who is like us! These people conform to our view of how the world works, and therefore we like them for it.

Next time you are trying to persuade someone, consider first subtly pointing out and talking about your shared similarities.

#2 – THE GEORGE CLOONEY/HALLE BERRY EFFECT

Are attractive people more persuasive?

Would you be more willing to say yes to a request by George Clooney or Halle Berry than you would to an average-looking person?

Even though it may seem unfair, it's true that attractive people are more persuasive. Attractive people are seen as being smarter, kinder and more talented than non-attractive people.

You might be shaking your head and saying, "No, that might be true for other people but my decisions are not influenced by the attractiveness of the person doing the asking!"

It turns out that a lot of people hold that opinion. They believe that their decisions are not influenced by how attractive a person is.

However, science reveals otherwise. A research study conducted by Michael Efran and E.W.J. Patterson analyzed the effect of the attractiveness of the candidate on the 1974 Canadian federal elections. The study found that **attractive candidates received two-and-a-half times as many votes** as did unattractive candidates.

In another research study conducted by Reingen and Kernan, the researchers found that **attractive fundraisers received twice as many donations as non-attractive fundraisers**.

While this research may be disheartening for non-attractive individuals like myself, the reality is that attractive people tend to be more persuasive than less-attractive individuals.

So, what does this mean for you?

Does it mean that non-attractive folks such as myself are doomed to fail in our persuasion attempts? Absolutely not.

It does, however, mean that we need to pay careful attention to how we look. Apart from dressing well, make sure you take care of yourself. Learn how to take care of your skin and your body so that you look the best that you possibly can.

#3 – “MAY I COMPLIMENT THEE?”

We tend to like people who like us. I learned this concept first-hand as a high school teenager. When I found out that a girl in my class liked me, I began to like her too - even though previously I hadn't paid much attention to her.

One of the best ways to get someone interested in you is to be interested in them. Similarly, to get someone to like you, you have to like them first.

However, that raises the question: How do you get the other person to realize that you like them?

One of the easiest ways to show people you like them is to compliment them. One study (Drachman, de Carufel and Insko, 1978), found that **men who received compliments developed positive feelings towards the person who gave the compliment.** This was true even when the men receiving the compliments knew that that the person complimenting them wanted a favor from them.

Next time you want to persuade someone, gain their liking by liking them first. Show your liking for them by genuinely complimenting them.

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **Two Birds of a Feather:** At Tupperware parties, guests' liking for their host is twice as important (as compared to their opinion of the products) in influencing purchasing decisions. When dealing with prospects, be friendly, courteous and polite. Are you likeable?
- People are more likely to help out a stranger when he is dressed similarly to them than when he isn't. Are you dressing similarly to your prospect?
- **The George Clooney/Halle Berry Effect:** According to research, attractive political candidates receive two-and-a-half times as many votes as non-attractive ones. Also, attractive fundraisers receive twice as many donations as non-attractive ones. Are you well groomed?
- **"May I Compliment Thee?"** People who receive compliments develop positive feelings towards the person who gave the compliment. Are you genuinely complimenting your prospect?

CHAPTER TWO

WIIFM: GO TO THE EDGE



In the first chapter, we talked about how to increase your likeability so that you can increase your persuasion power. In this and the following chapters, we're going to discuss how to frame your persuasion attempt so that other people *want* to do what you tell them.

One of the most basic yet most important concepts in persuasion is to know your target's goals.

What are your target's goals?

What's important to him/her?

What benefit will your target receive as a result of doing what you ask them to do?

If you can demonstrate to your target how he/she will benefit from doing what you ask of them, then you've already won most of the persuasion battle.

Why?

Because any time you try to persuade someone, the first thing that they want to know (whether they tell you or not) is: **"WIIFM? What's in it for me?"**

If you can answer your prospect's WIIFM question with a compelling benefit, your prospect will be enthusiastic about complying with your request.

#4 - GO THE EDGE

In his book, *World Class Speaking*, Craig Valentine classifies the different benefits that motivate people into the acronym EDGE, which stands for:

- **Esteem More.** An “esteem-benefit” focuses on how your prospect will experience greater confidence and have more self-esteem because of saying “yes” to your request. Also, it focuses on how other people in your target’s circle will hold him/her in greater esteem (e.g. people will respect and appreciate him/her more) as a result of complying with your request.
- **Do More.** A “do-more” benefit focuses on how your target will manage to get a lot more done (i.e. be more productive) as a result of saying “yes” to you.
- **Gain More.** A “gain-more” benefit focuses on what your prospect will gain as a result of agreeing to your request (e.g. gain more money, gain more time, etc.).
- **Enjoy More.** An “enjoy-more” benefit focuses on the pleasure your target will experience (e.g. have more fun, experience more happiness, etc.).

For your sales pitch, it would be safe to cover at least one major benefit from each of the EDGE elements. However, if you know that your target is more interested in one of the elements than the others, then spend most of your time exploring that benefit in detail. For some people, this may be making more money whereas for others it may be experiencing greater happiness in life.

It is your job as a persuader to make sure you know what motivates your target. Research your target to find out which EDGE benefit they place greatest emphasis on. Always frame your persuasion attempts in terms of what benefits your target will receive.

#5 – THE “STAR WARS” TOOTHBRUSH TECHNIQUE

When trying to persuade your target, always make sure that you try to make your benefits as specific as possible. For example, when I try to persuade corporations to hire me as a public speaking trainer, instead of saying, “Your employees will be better speakers,” I say, “You’re employees will walk away from my seminar twice as good as when they first came in!”

According to research studies, **specific benefits are more memorable, exciting and perceived as being more credible than non-specific benefits**. Specifics paint a clear picture of the benefits in your target's mind and thus create excitement.

Consider the difference between me telling you, "If you participate in this lottery, you stand the chance to go on a relaxing vacation!" and "If you participate in this lottery, you stand the chance to win an all-expenses-paid, two-week vacation in Mauritius!"

Which one could you *see* in your mind? I'm betting it was the latter. The "all-expenses-paid, two-week vacation in Mauritius" probably had you picturing yourself sitting on a nice, sunny beach in Mauritius. That's the power of specifics!

In a 1986 experiment conducted by Jonathan Shedler and Melvin Manis at the University of Michigan, participants were assigned the role of a juror. As part of the experiment, the participants were given a case to read and asked to decide whether they thought Mrs. Johnson was capable of continuing to care for her seven-year-old son.

Some of the participants were given Case A to read whereas some of the others were given Case B. This is part of what the participants read in the respective cases:

CASE A (FOR Mrs Johnson): "Mrs. Johnson sees to it that her child washes and brushes his teeth before bedtime. He uses a "Star Wars" toothbrush that looks like Darth Vader."

CASE B (FOR Mrs Johnson): "Mrs. Johnson sees to it that her child washes and brushes his teeth before bedtime."

CASE A (AGAINST Mrs Johnson): "The child was sent to school with a badly scraped arm, which Mrs. Johnson had not cleaned or attended to. The school nurse had to clean the scrape."

CASE B (AGAINST Mrs Johnson): "The child was sent to school with a badly scraped arm, which Mrs. Johnson had not cleaned or attended to. The school nurse had to clean the scrape. As the nurse was cleaning the scrape, she spilled Mercurochrome on herself, staining her uniform red."

Did you pick up the subtle difference between Case A and Case B?

Case A contained the specific detail of the child using a “Star Wars” toothbrush and Case B contained the specific detail of the nurse “staining her uniform red.”

The researchers were curious to see whether these two details (which, according to common sense, should not make a difference in people’s judgment of Mrs. Johnson’s ability as a mother) would affect the participants’ decisions.

Surprisingly, it turned out that they did! **Those who read Case A (the one that contained the specific detail about the “Star Wars” toothbrush) rated Mrs Johnson, on average, a 5.8 in terms of suitability as a mother, whereas those who read Case B only rated her a 4.3 (out of 10).**

What this research illustrates is that specific details unconsciously impact people’s decisions. Specifics make it easier for listeners to imagine the situation, which in turn makes the situation seem more *real* and credible than it really is.

Next time you try to persuade someone, be sure to include lots of specific benefits that paint vivid pictures in your target’s mind. The better your target can picture the benefits, the more likely he/she is to say “yes” to your request.

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **Go the EDGE:** Frame your benefits around your prospect’s EDGE needs. When persuading your prospect, are you clearly demonstrating to your prospect how they will experience greater self-esteem, be able to do more and gain more, as well as enjoy more as a result of doing whatever it is that you want them to do?
- **The “Star Wars” toothbrush technique:** Jurors who read the case that contained the specific detail about the “Star Wars” toothbrush rated Mrs Johnson, on average, a 5.8 in terms of suitability as a mother, whereas those who read the case without the detail only rated her a 4.3. Are you being super specific or being very vague when you talk about the benefits your prospect will experience?

CHAPTER THREE

THE EXPERT SPILLOVER EFFECT, GEEK STREET AND OTHER COOL TECHNIQUES



Framing your ideas and products in terms of your prospects' wants and needs (answering their WIIFM question) is a great way of persuading them to adopt your ideas and buy your products.

#6 – THE EXPERTISE ADVANTAGE

However, even then, you will encounter resistance if people doubt your credibility - if they don't believe that you're an expert on the solution or idea you're selling. On the other hand, if you do come across as an expert - as a credible source of information - then it's going to be much easier to get people to do what you want them to do. According to a paper written by Eric Jaso:

“...research done by Tsai, Chin, and Chen (2010) concerning the effects of trust and expertise from salespersons and the consumer's intention to purchase nutraceuticals reveals further correlation between source expertise and persuasive success.

“In the study, salespersons with high expertise attempted to sell nutraceuticals to customers. **The study revealed that the consumers who felt the salespersons were competent were more likely to purchase the nutraceuticals**, ‘since nutraceuticals are complex products with medicine-like effects, if the salesperson appears to have sound medical knowledge, this might help consumers to have a better understanding of the properties of the nutraceuticals, and increase their purchase intention’ (Tsai et al., 2010, p. 283).” - Eric Jaso, [*“The Dimensions of Source Credibility and Salesperson Persuasion”*](#)

Since the correlation between expertise and persuasion is clear, let's have a look at how you can establish your credibility and expertise.

#7 – “SEE MY DECORATED WALL?”

The quickest way to establish your expertise is by showcasing your relevant credentials and achievements.

Can you think of a time when you were ever swayed by someone's credentials and achievements?

Perhaps you walked into someone's office and saw their wall decorated with degrees and awards?

How did that make you feel? Did you trust that person more?

Let me put it to you another way: Who would you be more willing to take business advice from - a high school dropout or a Harvard MBA graduate?

I'm betting, given all other things are the same, you're more likely to pay for business advice from the person with the MBA.

So, why are degrees and awards such great credibility boosters?

Because they serve as proof that the person who has been granted the degree or the award has sufficient expertise of the subject matter in question. While this isn't necessarily true, it's hard to argue that having a degree or winning an award increases your *perceived* credibility.

Given this, here's my tip to you: If you do have several degrees, awards and qualifications, hang those up on your office wall. When prospects walk into your office, they will notice the awards and the degrees, and unconsciously they will begin to see you as an expert in that field.

Side note: I didn't say that you should *tell* your prospect about your degrees and awards. Starting your conversation with, "I have a PhD in microbiology and recently was awarded the XYZ Prize for outstanding contributions to science..." is a surefire way for getting your prospect to dislike you. You'll come across as an arrogant,

pompous jerk and if your prospects don't like you, they won't buy from you (whether it's your ideas or your products).

Avoid *talking* about your awards and achievements - it's better for your prospect to *see* them (if possible) or hear about them from someone else. If this isn't possible (e.g. if it's not possible to meet in your office), then don't push it - there are plenty of other ways to increase your perceived credibility.

Of course, there is a caveat to this: Make sure the qualifications are relevant to the idea or product you're pitching. If you're selling medical products but your degree is in ancient history, it's not going to do much for your credibility.

#8 – THE EXPERT SPILLOVER EFFECT

Another great way to increase your perceived credibility is to hang around other experts. When you associate yourself with other experts, their credibility spills over onto you and people begin to perceive *you* as an expert. That's why I encourage you to network with other experts. Attend networking events and get to know the movers and shakers in your industry. Also, join industry conferences and associations - that's where you'll meet the other experts and begin to develop relationships with them.

Now, this isn't a get-credibility-quick scheme. This strategy won't show instant results. Don't expect to hang out with experts one day and be seen as an expert the next day. This strategy is a long-term strategy - it will take a long time. However, the payoff is worth it.

If you become the kind of person who is well respected and liked by other experts in your field, the word will eventually spread that you're an expert who knows what you're talking about - and prospects will come to you instead of you having to chase after them!

HOW I ESTABLISHED MYSELF AS AN EXPERT - EVEN THOUGH I WAS A TWENTY-SOMETHING KID WITH NO CREDENTIALS OR CONNECTIONS

Getting others to perceive you as an expert is not very difficult. I know because I've done it, even though I was a 21-year-old with no credentials and no connections. Apart from attending industry conferences and networking events, here are the exact steps I used to establish myself as an expert:

9 – “I’M A BLOGGER, BABY!”

To establish myself as an expert on communication and persuasion, I started a blog where I shared advice and research about communication. I blogged once a week for a period of one year, sharing my best advice for free. I shared my articles on my social media pages, and soon I began to gather a small fan base.

During that period, I went from having zero followers to having 1,600 email subscribers. More importantly, my friends on my social media pages began to see me as an expert and began to refer potential clients to me.

Not only that, potential clients began to find me on the web and contact me to train them. I was even approached by the training director of Morgan Stanley (Hong Kong) to train their staff on public speaking and storytelling skills.

10 – AUTHOR TO AUTHORITY

The next step towards establishing myself as an expert was to write a book. When people see that you’ve written a book, they instantly perceive you as an expert on that topic - after all, you wrote a book on it! I spent two years researching and writing my first book, and since then have self-published six books on various different topics from [public speaking to persuasion to personal productivity](#).

Writing these books takes hard work and commitment, but having readers post positive reviews about the book on Amazon has helped solidify my status as an expert. In fact, through my books, I even landed a major speaking gig in Dubai.

If possible, I encourage you to write a book. Not only will your prospects begin to view you as an expert once they find out that you’ve written a book, it will help you *become* an expert because writing a book requires a lot of research and self-study.

11 – GEEK STREET

It’s great to be perceived as an expert, but it’s more important to *be* an expert. The best way to gain expertise in your chosen field is to read great books on your topic - become a book geek.

I read a minimum of 70 books every year, sometimes reading as many as 120. I read religiously every day to expand my knowledge base and to continually keep growing in my profession. The only reason I was able to blog consistently and write great books was because I am a great reader.

Develop the *habit* of reading every day - even if it's one or two pages daily. There is a saying that "average people have big TVs, extraordinary people have big libraries." Through my research on success, I have found this to be true. Extraordinary people - people who have reached the top of their professions, like Bill Gates, Oprah, Bill Clinton - are all voracious readers. If you want to be an expert, you should be one too. You're already on the right track since you're reading *this* book.

12 - THE SPEAKER'S BLESSING

Speaking in public is a brilliant way to demonstrate your expertise. After I'd created my blog, I emailed high schools, universities, chambers of commerce and business associations offering to run training sessions for them for free.

That's right - I did it for free because the aim wasn't to make money, it was to establish my expertise. After speaking at these universities and associations, I was able to feature their logos (with their permission) on my website. This increased my credibility when I interacted with prospects and thus they were more willing to buy from me.

What's your area of expertise?

I encourage you to email and call up universities and any relevant organizations, offering to run free training courses for them. Not only will you establish yourself as a local expert in your field, you might also end up with new clients (I did!).

13 – THE OPRAH STAMP

Did you know that it's relatively easy to get booked for a TV appearance? But first, why would you want to appear on TV or radio anyway?

It turns out that people who are featured on TV, radio or newspapers are perceived as experts. If you make an appearance on CNN or Oprah, people regard you as an expert. After all, if you're good enough to be trusted by Oprah (I call this the *Oprah Stamp*), you're good enough for everyone else (at least, that's the thinking).

However, you don't have to be booked by CNN, or FOX, or BBC in order to be regarded as an expert. Even a short appearance on a relatively unknown TV show is enough to make others perceive you as a local expert.

The good news is that it's very easy to get on a TV show. I know because I've done it. Here I am on a TV show in Malaysia. I was traveling through Malaysia when I decided that it would be fun to be on TV (even though I had no connections to any TV hosts or journalists):



Here I am on a TV show in the Philippines (again, I was just traveling through when I decided it would be cool to be on a local channel):



So, how did I manage to get on these TV shows despite having no local connections? Very simply, I logged onto my LinkedIn account (<http://www.Linkedin.com>) and searched for “TV hosts” in Malaysia and the Philippines:

People Jobs

Advanced People Search

Keywords
TV Hosts

First Name

Last Name

Title

Company

School

Location
Located in or near: ▾

Country
Malaysia ▾

Relationship
☐ 1st Connections
☐ 2nd Connections
☐ Group Members
☐ 3rd + Everyone Else

Location

Current Company

Industry

Past Company

School

Profile Language

Groups
☐ BEvents.biz
☐ Communication Professionals
☐ Copywriters International
☐ Corporate Communication
☐ Corporate Speech Professionals

Years of Experience

Function

Seniority Level

Interested In

Company Size

Fortune

When Joined

Reset Close

LinkedIn generated a list of TV hosts, and I sent them all customized messages introducing myself and asking if they would be interested in having me on their show.

In fact, here is the exact email I sent that resulted in me landing three TV show segments in Malaysia:

Thanks for connecting via LinkedIn.

I'm impressed with your work with at Capital TV.

I'm writing to you because I'll be in Malaysia starting Dec 18 and I'm interested in networking with others in the communication profession. I'm also wondering if we can explore the possibility of me being a guest on one of your shows on Capital TV? Maybe I could be one of the guests you interview or maybe someone you know would be interested in my expertise?

Let me briefly introduce myself. My name is Akash and I'm a professional speaker and public speaking coach who was based in Hong Kong. I got "kicked out of Hong Kong" and so I decided to take turn this setback into an opportunity, and now I'm travelling the world...

The above is just a partial screenshot of the email I sent. Here's the full transcript of the email in case you are interested:

"Hi (Name of Host),

Thanks for connecting via LinkedIn.

I'm impressed with your work with at Capital TV.

I'm writing to you because I'll be in Malaysia starting Dec 18 and I'm interested in networking with others in the communication profession. I'm also wondering if we can explore the possibility of me being a guest on one of your shows on Capital TV? Maybe I could be one of the guests you interview or maybe someone you know would be interested in my expertise?

Let me briefly introduce myself. My name is Akash and I'm a professional speaker and public speaking coach who was based in Hong Kong. I got "kicked out of Hong Kong" and so I decided to take turn this setback into an opportunity, and now I'm travelling the world...

Would you be interested in meeting up over a cup of coffee because I'd love to sit down with you and pick your brain?

Plus, I see you have been featured on very many media outlets. I'm wondering if you might be able to give me tips on which people to approach if I'd like to be interviewed on TV in Malaysia. I managed to get a TV interview in Philippines, and I'm looking to do the same in Malaysia. Possible?

In any case, I'm a fan after reading your profile and would love to meet up over coffee. I can meet you at a place that most convenient for you. If we could meet up even for a couple of minutes, that would be great :-)

Oh, and if you're interested, here are some of the topics I specialize in as a speaker:

#Social Media Marketing - how to grow your business with social media

#Blogging - How to create new fans for your business through blogging

#Mindset - How to develop a positive attitude and turn setbacks into successes

#Communication - powerful communication techniques to persuade people and create loving relationships.

#Travel - how to travel the world for free using Facebook, LinkedIn and blogging...[which is what I'm doing right now]

What do you say?

Please do let me know if we might be able to meet while I'm in Malaysia (I'll make my way over to where you are at a time that's convenient to you!)

Cheers,
Akash"

To be honest, if I was to rewrite that email, I would write a better, more customized one. However, as you can see, even that not so great email resulted in me getting a "Yes!"

Local TV shows are always looking for guests and new content, so you will find that it is relatively easy to get a spot on a local TV channel - and that will be a huge credibility boost for you.

After your appearance on the TV show (or radio), be sure to put a segment of the show on your website or blog so that any prospects who decide to Google you will see it.

14 – THE ANECDOTAL TESTIMONY

The above strategies will help establish you as an expert. However, there is no guarantee that your prospect will check out your blog, or watch your media interviews. Despite your best efforts to become well known locally as an expert, your prospect might not have heard of you.

What do you do in this case?

How can you establish your expertise on the spot?

One of the easiest ways to gain credibility, demonstrate your competence and establish your expertise is to showcase testimonials from previous clients. There are two ways to do this.

The first way is to casually slip in stories about your previous clients. During your conversation with your prospect, share a story about someone who is similar to them who benefitted from the idea or product you are selling. This story serves as anecdotal proof that your ideas and products work, and that you know what you're talking about.

However, make sure you slip this story very casually into the conversation. You do this by using natural conversational transitions such as, "By the way, I had a client similar to you..." or "That reminds me of a client who..."

In any case, make sure that your prospect doesn't feel like you're trying to hard sell them. People don't like hard sells. They don't like being persuaded. **Your persuasion attempt should be very soft and disguised as a casual conversation, not a sales pitch.** You should ask plenty of questions and allow for back-and-forth dialogue instead of delivering a one-sided sales pitch.

15 – THE “DON’T BE AN IDIOT” STRATEGY

Here’s the most important way to be seen as an expert: be one!

In order to be seen as a competent person, you need to *be* a competent person. This means that you constantly need to be investing in yourself by attending seminars and workshops and getting mentorship from other experts in your field.

I just came back from a meeting where I accompanied one of the sales executives in my company to meet a prospective customer. I went with her to evaluate her sales skills and to see what areas she might require training in.

The company I work with deals in the IT sector, so salespeople need to be experts on IT related matters. However, during the meeting, it became very clear that the sales executive lacked IT knowledge. She was unable to answer the client’s technical questions - and it became obvious from the client’s body language that he was beginning to doubt our competence.

As a result of lack of knowledge, we lost that sale. The salesperson failed to persuade the client because she didn’t know what she was selling. She wasn’t an expert on the solution she was selling.

Last night, I was watching a video by John Maxwell, and in the video he said something that struck a chord with me. He said, “You cannot give what you do not have.” Convincing your prospect to do something is really about getting your prospect to buy into your expertise - to believe that you have specialized knowledge that they do not have and that it will benefit them.

However, if you do not have expertise, you cannot sell your expertise. You can try to fake it, but your prospect will detect your deception.

Thus, the best strategy for being perceived as an expert - as a credible source of information - is to actually *be* one!

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **The Expertise Advantage:** There is a direct relationship between competence and persuasion. If people see you as an expert, they are more likely to allow themselves

to be persuaded by you. Are you an expert in your field? Do other people perceive you as one?

- **“See My Decorated Wall?”** Showcase your relevant qualifications on your website and in your office. What qualifications do you have that would demonstrate to other people that you are an expert in your field?
- **The Expert Spillover Effect:** Hang around other experts and people will begin to perceive you as one too. Are you attending networking events and industry conferences and associating yourself with other experts in your field?
- **“I’m a Blogger, Baby!”** Share your expertise on your blog. Give your best advice away for free online. Are you blogging at least once a week?
- **Author to Authority:** Authors are seen as authorities. Publishing a book will result in clients coming to you instead of you having to chase after them. Are you planning to write a book?
- **Geek Street:** Continually expand your knowledge base by reading great books. Are you reading at least one great book per month?
- **The Speaker’s Blessing:** Public speaking is a great method for sharing your expertise and establishing yourself as an expert in your field. What schools, universities, chambers of commerce and associations can you offer to speak at?
- **The Oprah Stamp:** Ask to appear on TV shows and news programs. Being featured on Oprah would do wonders for your career, but even getting a speaking slot on a local TV channel will help establish you as a local expert. Which local channels would be interested in hearing from you?
- **The Anecdotal Testimony:** During conversations with your prospect, casually slip in stories and testimonials about your previous clients in order to establish your competence. What client success stories can you share with your prospect?
- **The “Don’t be an Idiot” Strategy:** Don’t be an idiot. The best way to be seen as an expert is to be one. Are you continually investing in yourself? What are you doing daily in order to increase your expertise on your chosen subject matter?

CHAPTER FOUR

THE YES LADDER: PUTTING YOUR TARGET INTO AN AGREEMENT MINDSET



Before we dive into this next technique, let's look at the research behind it.

In a research study conducted by Jing Xu and Robert Wyer, participants who described themselves as Republican or Democrat were randomly assigned to watch either a video of speech by Barack Obama (a Democrat) or a video of a speech by John McCain (a Republican). Afterwards, all the participants watched a TV ad for Toyota and were asked to report their attitudes towards Toyota.

What were the results of the study?

It turns out that **Democrats found the ad more persuasive after watching the speech by Obama, whereas Republicans were more easily persuaded by the ad after watching the speech by McCain.**

According to Jing Xu and Robert Wyer:

“The effect of a persuasive communication on individuals' attitudes can be influenced by the cognitive behavior they have performed in an earlier, unrelated situation... Watching a political speech or debate activated different mindsets, depending on participants' a priori attitude toward the politicians involved, and these mindsets influenced the impact of an unrelated commercial they considered later.”

In other words, you can increase your odds of getting a “Yes” from your target by making sure that he/she is in an agreement mindset before you try to persuade him/her.

16 – THE “YES LADDER”

How do you get your target into an agreement mindset?

First and most obvious, make sure that your target is in a positive mood before you try to persuade him/her.

Now here’s the less obvious part. It’s one of my favorite techniques. I call it the “yes ladder.” With this technique, you ask your target a series of questions to which you know he/she will say “yes.”

Alternatively, you can make statements that your target agrees with.

These questions and statements don’t necessarily have to be related to the idea/product you’re trying to sell. The idea behind this technique is not to try to persuade your target just yet - it is to put her into an agreement mindset so that she will be more likely to say “yes” when you do try.

Does this technique work?

As the research by Jing Xu and Robert Wyer shows, **people who watched speeches that agreed with their worldviews (and thus put them in an agreement mode) were more easily persuaded by the advertisements that they watched.** We can thus safely assume that this technique works not just for ads, but also for general persuasion attempts.

The other benefit of the “yes ladder” technique (especially if you’re making statements which your target agrees with) is that it builds rapport between you and your target. It shows your target that you are similar to him/her, and as we discovered in Chapter 1, similarity creates liking, which in turn makes it easier for you to persuade people.

Next time you try to persuade someone, first put them into an agreement mindset by asking them questions or making statements that your targets agree with.

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **The “Yes Ladder”:** Put your prospect into an agreement mindset by first making statements that you know your prospect will agree with. When you then transition into your persuasion attempt, you will more easily persuade your prospect. Are you putting your prospects into a yes mindset before you try to persuade them?

CHAPTER FIVE

THE FAIR PERSUADER: ONE-SIDED VERSUS BALANCED ARGUMENTS



Which is more persuasive: a one-sided argument (that looks at only the merits of an issue) or a balanced argument (which looks at both the merits and drawbacks of an issue and then offers counter-arguments)?

If you were trying to persuade someone that your political party's economic policies were the correct one, what do you think would be more persuasive to them:

(A) A one-sided argument that focused only on the benefits of your party's economic policies?

Or

(B) A balanced argument that examined the benefits of your party's economic policies, acknowledged some of the weaknesses and then offered counter-arguments?

Which approach do you think most people would take?

Generally, when trying to persuade people to "do stuff," most people only present a one-sided argument - they talk only about the benefits of the idea/product. We're scared that pointing out weaknesses in our ideas/products will reduce our persuasiveness. We believe that if we only talk about the pros of an idea/product and ignore the drawbacks, then perhaps other people won't realize the drawbacks of what we're selling.

But is this really the best way to persuade people?

17 – THE FAIR PERSUADER

Daniel O’Keefe at the University of Illinois wondered exactly the same thing. He did a meta-analysis of over a hundred different studies that looked at the issue of one-sided versus balanced arguments and came to the following conclusion: **two-sided arguments were more persuasive than one-sided arguments (but *only* when two-sided arguments also provided counter-arguments).**

In other words, the most persuasive argument is one that talks about the benefits of a particular course of actions, acknowledges that there might be some drawbacks but then offers counter-measures or counter-arguments that minimize the effect of the drawbacks.

Apart from shooting down possible objections before your target even raises them, the benefit of a balanced argument is that it makes you look like a fair, rational and logical person.

By acknowledging the weaknesses in your argument, you show your target that you’re someone who’s looked at the pros and cons of the idea and then come to a logical conclusion (as opposed to being a slick salesperson who turns a blind eye to any weaknesses in your ideas/products). This makes it easier for your target to trust you - they see you as a trustworthy persuader - which in turn makes it easier for you to persuade the target.

Next time you try to persuade someone, avoid the temptations to hide the weaknesses in your argument. Instead, point out those weaknesses before your target does, and then offer counter-arguments that make the weaknesses seem insignificant. This way, you’ll get rid of your prospect’s potential objections before she even raises them and you’ll come across as a rational expert who has weighed both the pros and cons in order to come to a logical decision.

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **The Fair Persuader:** Create the perception that you are a fair persuader by offering what appears to be a fair and balanced argument, but then offer counterarguments that make your idea/product seem like the best choice.

CHAPTER SIX

INOCULATION



In the previous chapter, we discovered that two-sided arguments are more persuasive than one-sided arguments, but *only* when two-sided arguments also provide counter-arguments.

These counter-arguments are vital because they inoculate the audience against the opponent's arguments. Inoculation is a very important part of persuasion.

What is inoculation? According to an article on Education-Portal.com:

“Attitude inoculation is a technique used to make people immune to attempts to change their attitude by first exposing them to small arguments against their position. It is so named because it works just like medical inoculation, which exposes a person's body to a weak version of a virus. The weakened virus triggers the production of antibodies in response, but it is not strong enough to overwhelm the body's resistance. Later, when exposed to the full virus, the body knows what to expect and is better able to resist than it would have been before the inoculation.

“Attitude inoculation, then, exposes a person to a weak logical argument that is contrary to their preexisting attitude. This triggers the creation of counterarguments in response. Later, when exposed to a strong persuasion technique that attempts to change their preexisting attitude through logic, the individual already has arguments to use in defense.”

In other words, to immunize your prospect against counter-persuasion attempts (either by himself or by others), you need to present him with a weak attack against the idea or product you are trying to sell, and then shoot down that attack with a counter-argument.

Essentially, this is what you are doing when you offer a balanced argument - you examine the benefits of your position, acknowledge some of the weaknesses and then inoculate your prospect against those weaknesses by offering counter-arguments to those weaknesses. This arms your prospect with a list of arguments that your prospect can use to defend your position if someone tries to challenge it.

Here's a great example of inoculation in action in the political arena from HealthyInfluence.com:

“...some really interesting new research shows that you can inoculate voters in political campaigns. For example, the Republican Party would send out literature to potential Republican voters warning them that the Democrats are likely to attack the Republican candidate on various issues. The literature would provide a weak version of the attacks which the voter would easily defeat. Then when the real Democrat attack comes, the potential Republican voter would fight it off.”

18 – INOCULATION

Here's another example of how well inoculation works. In a study conducted by Cheryl Perry, the researchers wanted to see if they could inoculate adolescents against pro-smoking arguments so that they could reduce the chances that these children would become smokers.

Most children under the age of 12 usually hold negative attitudes about smoking, but when they get into high school, peer pressure to be “cool” and the pressure to fit in results in a large number of these children becoming smokers.

The researchers wanted to test if it was possible to reduce teenage smoking rates through inoculation. Therefore, they conducted an experiment and got a group of children to role-play how they would handle situations such as being called a “chicken” for not smoking. In order to inoculate them against smoking, these students practiced responding to peer-pressure by saying things such as, “I’d be a real chicken if I smoked just to impress you!”

The results of this experiment were astounding. **The children who had been inoculated against pro-smoking (and peer pressure) were 50% less likely to become smokers than children who had not been inoculated.**

As this experiment shows, inoculation is powerful. It works!

Whether they did it consciously or not, my parents inoculated me against smoking and drinking at an early age. Since the age of 14, I remember my parents casually telling me things such as, “I know that there may be pressure on you to smoke and drink because your friends might be doing it - they might even say you’re ‘not cool’ for not joining in - but you should just tell them, ‘I’d rather be uncool than smoke just because you’re doing it!’”

Like any teenager, I used to hate listening to my parents tell me what to say. However, the inoculation worked because I never gave into peer pressure. Whenever I was offered a cigarette or a drink and made fun of for not joining in, I used a similar version of what my parents told me and rejected my friends’ persuasion attempts to join in on their rebellious activities.

To this day, I do not smoke or drink and have never experimented with drugs. For that, I give the full credit to my parents for raising me the way they did. Whether they were aware of it or not, they used a very powerful persuasion technique to keep me away from cigarettes, alcohol and drugs.

When you are trying to inoculate your prospect against counter-persuasion attempts, you probably can’t get them to role-play.

However, what *can* you do?

The easiest way is to shoot down potential opposing arguments even before they are raised. You could say things such as, “Now, I know that a few people might say that our company is too new and this is true. However, all you have to do is look at our track record. We may be young in the marketplace, but we’ve had a successful track record of working with companies such as...”

You could also inoculate your prospect against possible counter-persuasion attempts from himself by saying, “I know you might be thinking that (insert possible objection

here), and I understand. I used to think the same way. However, what I have learned since is that..."

Side note: Notice how in the above two statements you are not arguing against the prospect. Instead, you are accepting and acknowledging what the prospect is saying, and then giving them a different perspective.

For example, in the first example, you are acknowledging that you are a young company, but then getting him to focus on the fact that you have a successful track record despite being new in the market. In the second statement, you are accepting that you too used to have the same objection that your prospect has, but then introducing him to a new piece of information showing him how that changed your mind, and which will hopefully change his too. In any case, never argue against the prospect because your prospect does not like being wrong. Trying to convince him he is wrong is a waste of your time. Instead, accept his objection and then give him some new information that changes their perspective.

I remember when I first accidentally stumbled across this great persuasion technique called inoculation. I was in high school and one of my subjects was economics. My economics teacher loved holding mock debates during class, and he'd pit students against one another and get us to debate the pros and cons of a particular economic policy.

During one such debate, I was supposed to argue against my opponent and prove to my class, once and for all, that the best type of economy was a free economy (whereas my opponent's job was to argue that the best type of market was a planned one). We'd been given several minutes to prepare our debates, after which I was the first person to get up and speak.

I began my argument by talking about the benefits of a free economy, but within a couple of minutes, I'd covered all my points and found that I still had two more minutes of speaking time remaining.

Not wanting to waste my speaking opportunity (plus, my teacher would have killed me if I'd finished speaking before time was up!) I said, "Now, I realize that my

opponent might say that..." I went on to talk about all the possible arguments that my opponent might make and then shot each one down with a counter-argument.

I knew I'd stumbled across a great persuasion technique when the class began applauding enthusiastically when I finished speaking. It wasn't because I was a good speaker (they'd never cheered for me before). It was the technique that made the difference. When my opponent stood up to make his argument, his entire argument seemed very weak because I'd already shot down his points before he'd even brought them up.

In sales training, salespeople are taught to shoot down any objections a customer might have before he can bring them up. Similarly, if you can shoot down any objections your target might have before he even brings them up, you'll leave your target no choice but to say "yes" to your request.

So, here's the key takeaway: Present what seems to be a balanced argument and then shoot down the opposing arguments in order to inoculate your prospect against counter-persuasion attempts.

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **Inoculation:** Research shows that children who are inoculated against pro-smoking (and peer pressure) are 50% less likely to become smokers than children who have not been inoculated. Use inoculation to ensure your prospect won't change his mind after giving you a "yes."

CHAPTER SEVEN

THE MINT SWEET AND OTHER EXPERIMENTS



Imagine that it's Christmas, and you're sitting at home on your comfy sofa, opening up your mail. While sorting through your mail - mostly Christmas cards from friends and family - you come across a card by a man named Phillip Kunz.

The card is handwritten, contains a pleasant note and a photograph of Phillip and his family. However, here's the interesting thing: Phillip is a complete stranger to you. You've never seen him, met him or even heard about him.

What do you do?

Do you send a Christmas card back to him, despite the fact that you do not know him?

THE RECIPROCATION EXPERIMENT

In 1974, this was the experiment conducted by a sociologist named Phillip Kuntz. **He mailed out Christmas cards to 600 strangers to see how many people would reply back. The results of the experiment were pleasantly surprising. Phillip received a total of 200 replies.**

Now, this leads to the question: why would people put in the effort to send a card to a stranger?

The answer is that when people do something nice for you, you feel obligated to do something for them in return. This is the rule of reciprocity.

Can you think of a time when you went out of your way to do a favor for someone - even if it was inconvenient for you - simply because they had done something nice for you in the past?

Reciprocity is a very powerful persuasion principle. If you want to persuade people to do something for you, you should first do something for them. Instead of going into a persuasion attempt thinking, “How can I get the most out of this exchange?” go into it thinking, “What can I do to help this person out?”

Focus on genuinely helping out your prospect and you will find that they will become much more open to what you are saying.

#19 - “HOW CAN I HELP YOU?”

When I was at the university, one of my negotiation professors - Stephen Nason - shared a story of how he managed to close a very tough deal using the law of reciprocation. He had been employed as a negotiator for a multinational company that did business in China. One day, while working, Stephen received a call from a large client who threatened to stop doing business with Stephen’s firm if Stephen did not reduce the prices of his goods.

Later that day, Stephen met up with the client. They met at the client’s offices, and after hours of negotiations, it was clear that the talks were getting nowhere. Finally, frustrated with their progress, the two men decided go to a bar for drinks. There, they began to chat about their life, and the conversation soon steered to the two men’s families. Notice how they began to build up liking towards each other by talking about shared experiences and interests.

Stephen found out that his client had a daughter who hoped to attend the same university that he had attended. Furthermore, she was hoping to get a scholarship at the university. Stephen knew some people who worked at the university, so later that night he connected his client’s daughters to some of the university staff who guided her through the admissions process.

Later that week, Stephen and the client met up once again. This time around, the client began by thanking Stephen for helping his daughter. Instead of threatening to terminate the relationship with Stephen’s firm, he was more open to exploring how they could both have a win-win situation.

In the end, Stephen was able to keep the client on board. The client accepted that there would not be a reduction in the prices, but they were able to work out a payment arrangement that both parties were happy with.

Why do I share this story with you? Because it's a powerful example of the law of reciprocation. The client was very initially very hostile, but after Stephen found a way to do something nice for him by helping out his daughter, the client felt (consciously or unconsciously) obligated to stop being hostile and help Stephen out in return by being more open to his side of the argument. As a result, the two parties were able to work out a deal that they were both happy with.

If you're trying to persuade your prospect to do something, and you're encountering a lot of resistance, then it might be a good idea to stop trying to persuade them and think about what your prospect values and what you can do to help them. Ask yourself, "How can I help this person?"

Next, when the right opportunity arises, do something nice for them - perhaps refer them to a prospective customer for their business. Do this without any expectation of getting anything in return - do it just because you genuinely want to help your prospect, not because you want to gain something from them in return.

Finally, wait for some time to pass before you approach your prospect again to try to persuade them. The reason you have to wait for some time to pass between doing them a favor and trying to persuade them again is because you do not want your client to feel manipulated. If your client feels that you helped them simply to get something from them in return, they will become resistant to your persuasion attempt.

#20 - THE MINT SWEET/COKE GIFT

In another study that was conducted on the power of reciprocation, **researchers discovered that waiters who gave their patrons a mint along with their bill received bigger tips than those who did not.**

Furthermore, **when the waiters gave their patrons a second mint and said that it was especially for them, the tips increased by 20 percent!** What's interesting

about reciprocation is that usually, the size of what you receive will exceed the size of what you give. This can be seen clearly in this study where the monetary value of the tip given far exceeded the monetary value of the mint. This phenomenon is also very clear in this next research study.

In a 1971 research study conducted by Dennis Regan of Cornell University, participants (also called “subjects”) were paired up for an “art appreciation” experiment. However, what the subjects didn’t know was that their partner - “Joe” - was actually Regan’s assistant. During the experiment, Joe would take a short break and return again after some time.

Now, here’s where the experiment got interesting - for some of the subjects, Joe would return with a soft drink, which he would give to the subject. For some of the other subjects, the assistant came back with nothing.

Next, the assistant would ask the subject to do him a favor and buy some raffle tickets. What do you think happened? Which group do you think purchased more raffle tickets - the group that was gifted the soft drink, or the control group that received nothing?

As expected, **the group that received the soft drink was more likely to purchase the raffle tickets, even though they had not asked for the soft drink** and even though the cost of the raffle tickets was greater than the cost of the drink.

WIDENING THE WINDOW OF PERSUASION

What this clearly demonstrates is that doing something nice for your prospect - doing your prospect a small favor even though they may not have asked for it - will induce the law of reciprocity. Your prospect will unconsciously feel a natural desire to do something in return for you. This doesn’t necessarily mean that they *will* buy from you. However, they will become more receptive to what you have to say. The window of persuasion will widen so that you can more easily sell your ideas and your products.

While reciprocation is a great persuasion tool, I advise you to use it with caution. Go in with the mindset of genuinely helping your prospect. However, if you use

reciprocation simply to manipulate your prospect, they will get a gut feeling that your favors are not genuine and this will backfire against you.

If you do favors for your prospect with the intention of helping them, over time you will build a strong friendship with them and they will come to trust you. Once that happens, it's not a matter of *if* they will buy from you - it's simply a matter of *when*.

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **The Mint Sweet Gift:** Researchers discovered that waiters who give their patrons a mint along with their bill receive bigger tips than those who do not. What small gift can you offer your prospects in order to start the cycle of reciprocation?
- **“How Can I Help You?”** Whenever you are trying to persuade someone, first ask yourself, “How can I be of help to this person?” Go into every persuasion encounter with the mindset of genuinely helping the other person.

CHAPTER EIGHT

THE PETRIFIED FOREST



One of the most powerful persuasion techniques is social proof. Advertisers and marketers know the power of social proof, which is why they use it so often in their marketing materials.

Social proof demonstrates to potential customers that a product is popular, causing the customers to think, “If so many people are buying the product, then it must be good!” For example, many people have a tendency to assume that just because a book is a “Number 1 New York Times Bestseller,” it must be a better book than the ones that didn’t make it to the bestseller list. While this might be the case, it is not always true.

“If you’ve ever noticed when really successful companies are making a sales presentation, they always provide examples of their most auspicious clients. They always tell you how Microsoft, eBay, and Pizza Hut were all wise enough to choose and benefit from their solution. When we hear that those big successful companies are using a solution, our subconscious automatically assumes this means it is a good solution.” - TreatYourLeads.com

THE HONG KONG NOODLE SHOP

One of the noodle shops I love eating at in Hong Kong uses this strategy very well. The restaurant - which is a small, medium-priced noodle shop - has an entire wall covered with pictures of the people who have visited the shop. It has pictures of happy, smiling customers posing with the owner.

The first time I went to the restaurant, I had stumbled into it simply because it was raining and I wanted to get out of the rain. However, when I entered the restaurant

and saw the wall full of happy customers, I decided that it was worth trying out the food.

Another reason social proof works so well in persuasion is because people want to fit into the groups that they associate themselves with. Research reveals that people don't like to be left out of a group (no big surprise there!).

Therefore, by using social proof (demonstrating that almost everyone in the group you associate yourself with is using your product), the marketer cleverly manages to convince you that if you don't buy his/her product, you'll be left out of the group.

As a blogger and Internet marketer, I am well aware of the power of social proof. A lot of blogs try to get you to subscribe to their newsletter. I have found that I am more willing to subscribe to a blog that touts that it has "Over 90,000 subscribers!" than to a blog that has only a handful of readers.

Similarly, I have found that I am more willing to "like" a page that has thousands of likes than to share one which has only several "likes." And, along the same lines, I am usually more willing to "like" a Facebook fan page that has several hundred thousand fans than to "like" a page which only has 40 likes.

Once I became aware of this technique, I started using it on my blog too. Ever since I added the words "Join over 4,200 other people and receive my free newsletter" above the email subscription form on my blog, I have seen an increased visitor-to-subscriber ratio (by the way, this is a true statistic).

Social proof is powerful because it lends credibility to and increases the perceived quality of the product being advertised. Furthermore, it activates people's fear of being left out of a group by implying that almost everyone is using the product.

Have you ever found yourself persuaded to do something (such as share a blog post, like a fan page or buy a product) because of social proof?

#21 – THE SITCOM LAUGHTER TRACK

Television studios realize the power of social proof, which is why a lot of TV sitcoms contain canned laughter. **Research has found that people who view sitcoms that**

have laughter tracks find the sitcoms to be funnier than sitcoms that don't.

Why?

Because the canned laughter serves as social proof, and when we hear people laughing (even if it is canned laughter), it causes us to laugh too.

One of my favorite TV shows is the American sitcom, *The Big Bang Theory*. I think that the show is hilarious. Recently, when I was watching the YouTube clips of the show, I came across a clip where the person who'd uploaded the clip had decided to get rid of the laughter tracks. When I watched the clip without the laughter track, it didn't seem so funny anymore!

In another example of the power of social proof, **researchers who joined a door-to-door charity campaign found that the longer the list of prior donors, the more likely it was that the person being solicited would donate as well.**

What does this mean for you?

If you're trying to persuade someone to do something, then use social proof to do so. Tell the person about how many other people who are similar to him are using your product/service/idea.

If relevant, provide testimonials to demonstrate social proof and show that people are happy because of following your recommended course of action.

NEGATIVE SOCIAL PROOF

Social proof encourages more of the behavior that is being advertised. In other words, if a person sees that your blog post has been shared by thousands of people he is more likely to share it too. If a sitcom viewer hears watches a show with a laugh track, she is more likely to laugh too.

The important point is: whichever action is demonstrated as being the one most people are taking is the one that other people will follow (whether you want it or not).

Why is this an important point?

Because people sometimes don't realize the unintended consequences of social proof.

#22 – THE PETRIFIED FOREST PERSUASION FAILURE

As an example of this, consider what happened when researchers put the following sign in the U.S. Petrified Forest National Park: “Many past visitors have removed the petrified wood from the park, destroying the natural state of the Petrified Forest.”

The sign was meant to discourage theft by showing that removing wood has resulted in destruction of the forest. It's the sort of message a lot of people use when trying to scare someone away from a behavior (e.g. “Most people don't recycle their trash, which results in destruction of the Earth. Please recycle your trash and help save the world!”).

Have you ever seen a message similar to this?

This type of message conveys negative social proof. It tries to discourage people from a particular behavior, but it demonstrates that a lot of people are engaging in that behavior.

So, what were the results of the sign that was put up at the Petrified Forest? Was the sign successful in painting the seriousness of the problem and hence reducing theft of the wood?

The results were shocking! **The negative social proof (“Many past visitors have removed the petrified wood...”) resulted in increased theft.** In fact, it tripled the amount of theft because it unconsciously made people think, “If everyone else is doing it, then why shouldn't I?”

Next time you're using social proof to persuade someone to do something, make sure you're not using negative social proof that results in the opposite of the desired behavior.

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **The Sitcom Laughter Track:** People who view sitcoms that have laughter tracks find the sitcoms to be funnier than sitcoms that don't. Similarly, researchers have discovered that for door-to-door charity campaigns, the longer the list of prior donors, the more likely it becomes that the person being solicited will donate. How can you harness the power of social proof in your persuasion attempts?
- **The Petrified Forest Persuasion Failure:** Using negative social proof (e.g. "Many past visitors have removed wood from the Petrified Forest") resulted in increased, rather than decreased, theft of petrified wood. Are you harming your persuasion attempt by using negative social proof?

CHAPTER NINE

THE ROKIA TECHNIQUE



In addition to the techniques we've discussed so far, another powerful tool in your persuasion toolkit is stories. Stories are very powerful and persuasive. Before I reveal to you the persuasive power of stories, let me tell you the story of Jared Fogle.

Jared Fogle was an overweight student at Indiana University who lost 245 pounds while on a "Subway diet." When Subway got wind of the story, they scrapped their previous commercial and used Jared Fogle in their commercial instead. **The Jared Fogle commercial was so successful that Subway sales jumped by almost 20%.**

A couple of years later, Subway decided to remove Jared from their commercials. Immediately, sales went down. Once Subway brought Jared's story back, sales shot back up.

So, why was it the Jared Fogle commercials were so successful?

What was it about Jared Fogle's story that persuaded people to buy Subway?

The Jared Fogle story was so successful because it aroused people's emotions. People make decisions based both on emotion and logic. The Jared Fogle story elicited emotions from the viewers (e.g. pain at seeing Jared overweight, frustration when Jared tries to lose weight but fails, and finally happiness when Jared loses weight because of the Subway diet).

Since the happiness at losing weight was associated with Subway sandwiches, this created a positive perception of Subway as a healthy choice ("Subway sandwiches must be healthy, because, after all, it did help Jared lose weight!").

I've told you that stories are powerful when it comes to persuading people, but what exactly are the elements of a persuasive story?

Simply, a persuasive story contains:

- **Characters** - At least one or more people must be a part of the story (e.g. Jared)
- **Conflict** - The characters must be encountering some kind of conflict/difficulty (e.g. being overweight and failing to lose weight)
- **Cure** - There must be a cure that helps the character overcome the conflict/difficulty (e.g. in Jared's case, the cure was the Subway diet)
- **Change** - The characters must change as a result of having overcome the conflict (e.g. Jared went from being overweight to being 245 pounds lighter)

#23: THE ROKIA TECHNIQUE

Now, let's look at an experiment conducted by Deborah Small, George Lowenstein and Paul Slovic. In the experiment, the participants were given a questionnaire to fill out and handed a \$5 reward for doing so.

Now, here comes the interesting part of the experiment. After the participants had received the \$5 bill, they were given information about a food shortage problem and asked how much of their \$5 they wanted to donate to help solve the problem.

However, not everyone received the same type of information. One group (we'll call them Group A) received the following information:

"Food shortages in Malawi are affecting more than three million children. In Zambia, severe rainfall deficits have resulted in a 42% drop in maize production from 2000. As a result, an estimated three million Zambians face hunger. Four million Angolans - one-third of the population - have been forced to flee their homes. More than 11 million people in Ethiopia need immediate food assistance."

The other group - Group B - received the following information:

“Any money that you donate will go to Rokia, a seven-year-old girl who lives in Mali in Africa. Rokia is desperately poor and faces a threat of severe hunger, even starvation. Her life will be changed for the better as a result of your financial gift. With your support, and the support of other caring sponsors, Save the Children will work with Rokia’s family and other members of the community to help feed and educate her, and provide her with basic medical care.”

Which group do you think gave more money? Was it the group that received the statistical information about the seriousness of the problem? Or was it the group that received the story about Rokia?

Well, let’s have a look at the experiment results.

It turns out that that participants **in Group A (the statistics group) donated only 23 percent of their earnings whereas participants in Group B (the story group) donated more than double that, 48 percent. The story about Rokia’s struggle with hunger elicited a much more powerful response from people than statistics about the problem.**

While statistics do add credibility to your persuasion attempts, stories are much more powerful when it comes to persuading people to take actions. Once you arouse people’s emotions, they’ll be open to taking the recommended course of action.

So here’s the key takeaway lesson. Next time you try to get someone to do something for you, use a story to persuade them.

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **The Rokia Technique:** Statistics inform but stories involve people emotionally. When trying to persuade people, are you using stories?

CHAPTER TEN

CLEAR NEXT STEP



An important part of getting people to say “Yes!” to your requests is make it clear what next step you would like your prospect to take. Do you want them to try out your product? Or to set up a second meeting? Or buy your product? What is your call to action? Be very clear and specific about what it is that you want your prospect to do.

If you do not make your next step crystal clear to your prospect, then you might end up losing the sale. If your prospect is even slightly confused about what to do next, he will say “No!” As one of my favorite speakers, Craig Valentine, puts it, “A confused mind says no!”

If you’re a salesperson trying to secure a meeting with a client, ask, “When should we schedule a time to meet? Does Monday or Tuesday work for you?”

If you’re an employee persuading your boss that you deserve a raise, at the end of your persuasion attempt politely ask the question, “So, can we increase my remuneration to X amount?”

#24: THE NEXT STEP

If you’re a reservation agent at a hotel in charge of getting potential guests who call to secure their reservation, then (as the following study shows) ask the callers, “So, should I go ahead and secure your reservation?”

In a study entitled “The factors that lead to more reservations: A statistical analysis of scored phone calls and bookings,” researchers analyzed 4,400 recorded phone calls from 30 hotels. The researchers were trying to figure out what techniques hotel employees were using that led to a customer making a reservation.

The results of the study were very interesting. **It turns out that simply offering to secure a reservation made it 440% more likely that the caller would make the reservation!** In other words, by giving the caller an exact next step - “should I go ahead and secure your reservation?” - the caller was 4.4 times more likely to make the reservation.

Whatever it is that you’re trying to persuade your prospect to do, make sure that you end with a request that makes it crystal clear what action your prospect should take next in order to comply with your request.

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **The Next Step:** Offering to secure a reservation at the end of a conversation makes it 440% more likely that the hotel guest will make the reservation. What’s the next step you want your prospect to take? Ask them to take it!

CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE COUNTERINTUITIVE PERSUASION TECHNIQUE THAT WORKS!



Of all the persuasion techniques I have come across, the following is one of the simplest and easiest to implement techniques. According to research, it can **double the chances that people will comply with your requests.**

Imagine for a second that you are out on the street taking a stroll when a stranger approaches and asks if you would please fill out a survey form for him. How likely are you to comply with the request?

#25 – THE BYAF TECHNIQUE

Now, consider that the person who's asked you to fill out the survey adds the following: "Please don't feel obliged to fill out the form, but I would appreciate it if you did." This is called the "BYAF" ("but you are free") technique.

How would that affect your decision?

Would you be more or less willing to say yes?

According to studies, it would. It turns out that the best way to get someone to do something for you is to tell them that they don't have to. **Using the BYAF technique can double your chances of getting a "yes."**

Why?

Because people don't like being pressured into making decisions - telling someone they *have* to do something causes psychological reactance in your prospect:

“It is assumed that if a person’s behavioral freedom is threatened or reduced, they become motivationally aroused. The fear of loss of further freedoms can spark this arousal and motivate them to re-establish the threatened freedom. Because this motivational state is a result of the perceived reduction of one’s freedom of action, it is considered a counterforce, and thus is called ‘psychological reactance.’” - [Wikipedia](#)

Haven’t you found this to be true in your life - that being told not to do something makes you want to do it more?

It even works if you restrict your own freedom. For example, I have found the following to be true. When I tell myself that, “I’m going to go on a strict diet. I can’t eat chocolate for the next year,” my desire to eat chocolate *increases!*

Side note: To combat this, I tell myself, “I can eat chocolate, but I choose not to.” This affirms my freedom - especially my freedom to *choose*. I have found that when I reaffirm my freedom to choose, I am much more likely to stick to my commitments. Try it out.

Similarly, when you reaffirm your prospect’s freedom to choose, you avoid psychological reactance. You remove any pressure associated with the request, which makes your encounter - from your prospect’s point of view - much more pleasant.

Does the actual wording of the BYAF technique matter?

No. You can use whatever phrase you desire - “you are free to choose,” “don’t feel obliged,” “you are free to say no.” As long as you reaffirm your prospect’s freedom to choose and say no, you will - ironically - increase your chances of getting a “yes.”

Next time you want to persuade someone to do something for you, use the BYAF technique. As long as your request is reasonable, using the BYAF technique will increase the chances that your prospect will go along with what you say.

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **The BYAF Technique:** Using the “but you are free” technique can double the chances your prospect will comply with your request. Are you pressuring your

prospects, or are you using the BYAF technique to reaffirm their freedom to choose?

CHAPTER TWELVE

WHAT TO DO IF YOUR PROSPECT SAYS NO



What if, after all this, your prospect *still* says no?

What should you do next?

How do you move forward from there?

#26 – THE POWER OF “WHY NOT?”

According to research conducted by Bolster, the “why not?” technique is very effective in increasing compliance rates. In one of Bolster’s research experiments, **participants who used the “why not?” technique achieved a compliance rate of 60%.** While this isn’t a fantastic compliance rate, keep in mind that this is a technique you can use to change your prospect’s mind even after he/she has said no.

So, what exactly is the “why not?” technique?

As the name suggests, the “why not?” technique refers to you asking your prospect, “Why not?” after he/she refuses your request. Listen carefully to your prospect’s objection, and then address it so that it is no longer an objection. If you can address the objection, most people will comply with your request because they have no reason not to.

The other benefit of the “why not?” technique is that it gives you useful information to create a better pitch for the next time you try to persuade a similar prospect. Let me give you an example: I am currently fortunate enough to be the Chief Commercial of a million-dollar company in Tanzania. It is my job to make sure that my salespeople meet their monthly targets. I have trained my salespeople to use the “why not?”

technique whenever a prospect refuses to buy from them. I can then use this information to create a more compelling offer.

Next time someone says no to you, ask them “why not?” and then clearly and succinctly address their objections. Not only will you be more likely to convince them, you will also get information that can help you when trying to persuade similar prospects in the future.

UNLOCK YOUR PERSUASION POWER

- **The Power of “Why Not?”:** When a prospect says “No,” use the “why not?” technique to uncover and address his/her objections. Participants in Bolster’s experiments who used the “why not?” technique achieved compliance rates of 60%. Try out the technique. Why not? You have nothing to lose! (See what I did there? ☺)

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

WRAP UP: YOUR PERSUASION PLAYBOOK



Persuasion is an art as well as a science. In this book, you've picked up tools and techniques on the science of persuasion. It is up to you to go out and apply the techniques - to master the *art* of persuasion and learn which techniques to apply in which situations.

While not all of your persuasion attempts will be successful, I encourage you to keep on persevering. I once read that “the more ‘no’s’ you get, the closer you are to a ‘yes’.” If something is important enough to you, you should keep persevering. While the words “don’t take no for an answer” are clichéd, they are true. If you persevere, your persuasion attempts will eventually pay off.

Let’s go through a quick recap of the tools and techniques covered in this book. Applying these techniques to your life - whether you are debating with your spouse about where to go on vacation or trying to persuade your boss to give you a pay raise - these techniques will increase your odds of getting your target to agree with you. Next time you try to persuade someone:

- Qualify your prospect. Make sure that he/she is, at the very least, willing to hear you out. You can’t persuade someone who’s unwilling to listen to you.
- Make sure your request will be perceived as reasonable.
- Present an offer that will genuinely benefit the person whom you’re trying to persuade.
- **Two Birds of a Feather:** At Tupperware parties, guests’ liking for their host is twice as important (as compared to their opinion of the products) in influencing

purchasing decisions. Make your prospect like you by appearing similar to them. Dress similarly to your prospect. Talk about shared interests.

- **The George Clooney/Halle Berry Effect:** Fundraisers more than double the contributions they receive simply by claiming a shared identity with the target person. Look your best self. Attractive people are more likeable and therefore more persuasive. While you don't have to have the looks of a Brad Pitt, make sure you're well groomed.
- **"May I Compliment Thee?"** People who receive compliments develop positive feelings towards the person who gave the compliment. Offer your prospect a genuine compliment because this creates mutual liking between you and your prospect.
- **Go the EDGE:** Answer the WIIFM question when pitching your proposal. Let your listeners know what benefits they will receive as a result of doing what you ask them. Frame your argument in terms of your listener's benefits. Your pitch shouldn't be about you and what you will receive - it should be about what your target will receive.
- Cover the EDGE benefits: Esteem More, Do More, Gain More, Enjoy More.
- **The "Star Wars" Toothbrush Technique:** Make your benefits super-specific. Specific arguments are more credible than vague ones.
- **The Expertise Advantage:** There is a direct relationship between competence and persuasion. If people see you as an expert, they are more likely to allow themselves to be persuaded by you.
- **"See My Decorated Wall?"** Showcase your relevant qualifications on your website and in your office.
- **The Expert Spillover Effect:** Hang around other experts and people will begin to perceive you as one too.
- **"I'm a Blogger, Baby!"** Share your expertise on your blog. Give your best advice away for free online to create establish your reputation as a local expert.

- **Author to Authority:** Authors are seen as authorities. Publishing a book will result in clients coming to you instead of you having to chase after them.
- **Geek Street:** Continually expand your knowledge base by reading great books and investing in seminars and workshops.
- **The Speaker's Blessing:** Public speaking is a great method for sharing your expertise and establishing yourself as an expert in your field.
- **The Oprah Stamp:** Ask to appear on TV shows and news programs. Being featured on Oprah would do wonders for your career, but even getting a speaking slot on a local TV channel will help establish you as a local expert.
- **The Anecdotal Testimony:** During conversations with your prospect, casually slip in stories and testimonials about your previous clients in order to establish your competence.
- **The "Yes Ladder":** Before you pitch your proposal, put your prospect into an agreement mindset using the "yes ladder" technique.
- **The Fair Persuader:** When trying to persuade your target, use a two-sided argument because balanced arguments are more persuasive since they are perceived as being more credible. Point out any obvious weaknesses in your proposal, but be sure to offer counter-arguments for any weaknesses so you can tip the scales in your favor.
- **Inoculation:** Research shows that children who are inoculated against pro-smoking (and peer pressure) are 50% less likely to become smokers than children who have not been inoculated. Use inoculation to ensure your prospect won't change his mind after giving you a "yes."
- **The Mint Sweet Gift:** Researchers discovered that waiters who give their patrons a mint along with their bill receive bigger tips than those who do not. Start up the cycle of reciprocation by first doing your prospect a favor
- **The Sitcom Laughter Track:** People who view sitcoms that have laughter tracks find the sitcoms to be funnier than sitcoms that don't.

- **The Petrified Forest Persuasion Failure:** Using negative social proof (e.g. “Many past visitors have removed the wood from the Petrified Forest”) resulted in increased, rather than decreased, theft of petrified wood. Be sure you are not using negative social proof.
- **The Rokia Technique:** People are hard-wired to listen to stories. Stories are how people make sense of the world - it’s how humans are wired to think - so use stories to make your persuasion attempts. Use the four C’s of storytelling to create a compelling and powerful story
- **The Next Step:** Make it very clear what next step you would like your prospect to take.
- **The BYAF Technique:** Using the “but you are free” technique can double the chances your prospect will comply with your request. Let your prospect know that he/she doesn’t have to feel obliged to say yes - which, ironically, increases your chances of them saying yes to your request.
- **The Power of “Why Not?”:** If your prospect says “no,” use the “why not?” technique to uncover and address their objections.
- **Keep Persevering:** Persuasion is about perseverance. Keep persevering and your persuasion attempt will eventually pay off. It’s not a matter of *if* your prospect will say, “Yes,” it’s simply a matter of *when*.

QUESTIONS OR COMMENTS?



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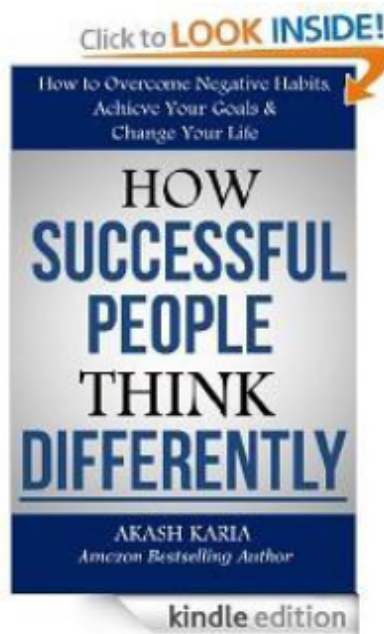
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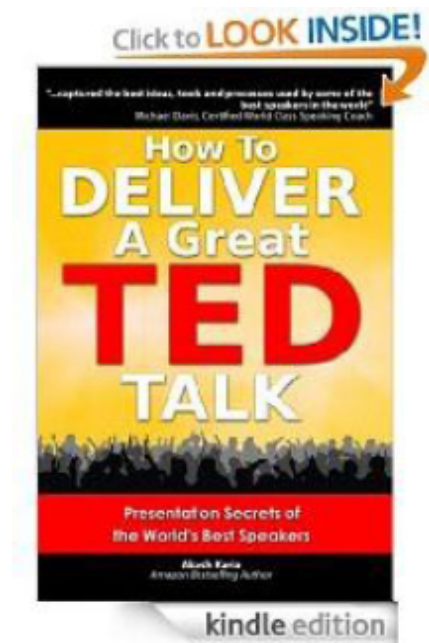
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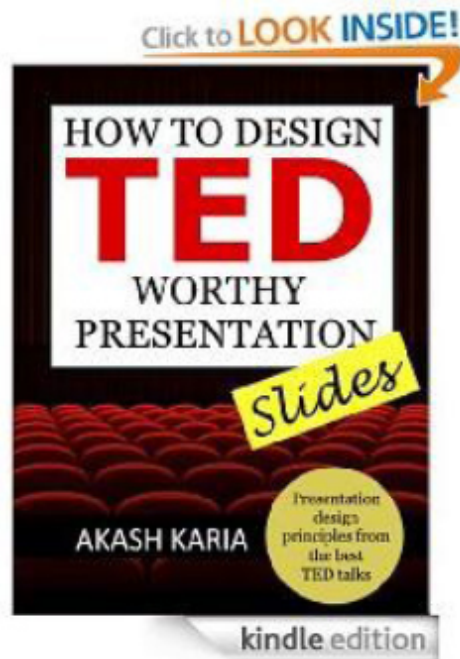
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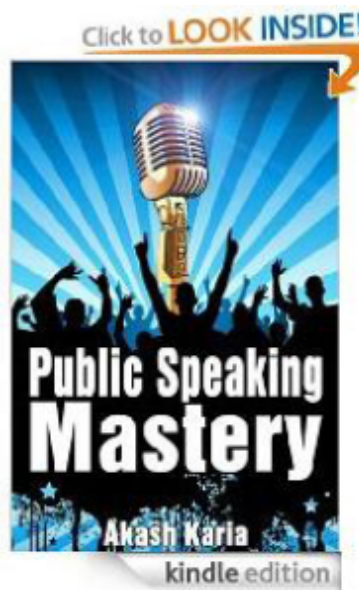


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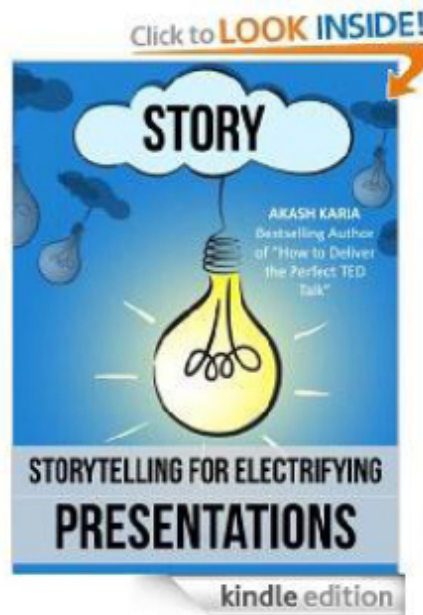
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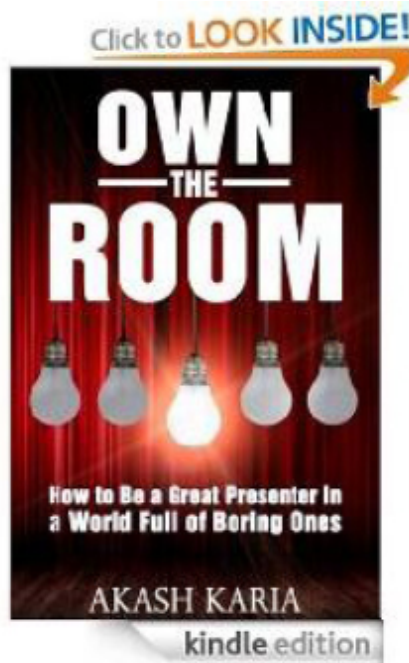


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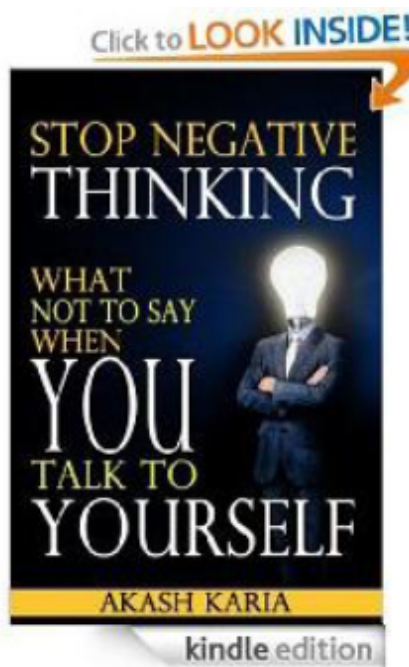
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